the West while a similar reaction would have ensued from the right in case of alliance with the communists. Averting polarization on foreign policy gave Nehru a relatively free hand in dealing with divisive politics over domestic problems. Nehru preferred cooperation and reasoning over confrontation and conflict. Nehru's speeches in the Constituent Assembly and later as prime minister reflect this desire for consensus and his hope that people 'who differ considerably in regard to our internal policy' would agree on a 'more or less unified foreign policy'.[37]

Subrahmanyam points out that Nehru had deployed non-alignment as a tactic specifically for the cold war but it became 'a moral code of conduct' for executing foreign policy in the post-Nehruvian era.[38] Journalist Inder Malhotra also echoed Subrahmanyam's views that for Nehru non-alignment was a policy, not a doctrine or a 'mantra to be chanted in season and out of season'. Malhotra recalls that on one occasion Nehru made a speech in the Indian parliament that 'he could not be non-aligned against himself'.[39]

In a recent book, Andrew Kennedy, professor, Australian National University, points out that Nehru's 'moralistic concern for world peace was not simply contrived for public purposes, it reflected his "genuine" concern about the world while protecting narrower Indian interests'. Non-alignment helped India diversify its relationships and prevent dependence on any one superpower. Kennedy also argues that Nehru sought to convert India into 'an industrial power in its own right' but knew that in the short term, India would need to be dependent on other countries. To prevent India from being involved in conflicts that would hurt her economic growth, Nehru chose the path of non-alignment. The idealist in Nehru, Kennedy argues, saw non-alignment 'as a means of maximizing India's influence' whereas the realist in him 'anticipated from the very beginning that a non-aligned stance would be difficult to maintain'.[40]

In a series of interviews conducted over several years, a majority of diplomats, both serving and retired, stated that while every country needs to